Circular Cities: Fix It, Don't Trash It

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Suppose your shoe splits, or a favorite toy breaks. Do you throw it away or fix it? Now imagine a whole city asking that question about almost everything.

That is the idea behind **circular** cities. About 100 communities around the world try to keep **materials** in use as long as possible, through repairs, reuse, and **recycling**, instead of sending them to the trash.

Most products follow a straight line. Companies gather raw **materials**, factories build products, people use them until they break, and then they are thrown away. Only a very small share get recycled. **Circular** cities aim for a closed loop instead.

Landfills are part of the problem. They are filling up, and most give off **methane**, a gas that warms the planet. Replacement products create still more pollution.

Austin, Texas, shows what a city can do. It runs a yearly toy-repair clinic and fix-it workshops. Amsterdam hopes to have almost no waste by 2050. As big buyers, cities can ask companies for greener goods. Just because something is broken does not mean its use has to stop.

Word Treasure

circular -- Going around in a loop, so things are used again instead of thrown away.

materials -- The stuff things are made from, like wood, metal, or plastic.

landfills -- Big places where trash is buried in the ground.

methane -- A gas that warms the planet.

recycling -- Turning old things into new materials or products instead of throwing them away.

Background you need

A circular city tries to keep things in use for as long as possible instead of throwing them away.

Broken items are repaired, reused, or recycled, so fewer new products need to be made and less trash piles up.

Landfills are places where trash is buried, and they can give off gases that warm the planet.

Break it down

WHO: Communities around the world, including the cities of Austin, Texas, and Amsterdam.
WHAT: Keeping materials in use through repairs, reuse, and recycling instead of sending them to the trash.
WHERE: About 100 communities around the world, including Austin, Texas, and Amsterdam.
WHY: Landfills are filling up, most give off methane that warms the planet, and replacement products create more pollution.

Why it matters

When your toy or shoe breaks, fixing it instead of throwing it away can help keep your city cleaner.

Test what you remember

1. What do circular cities try to do?

- (A) Ban all shops
- (B) Build more landfills
- (C) Throw away more things
- (D) Keep materials in use as long as possible

2. How do most products follow a straight line?

- (A) People fix everything forever
- (B) Companies gather raw materials, factories build products, people use them until they break, and then they are thrown away
- (C) Products are never used
- (D) Shops give everything away

3. What gas do most landfills give off?

- (A) Helium
- (B) Methane
- (C) Steam
- (D) Oxygen

4. What does Austin, Texas, run?

- (A) A ban on repairs
- (B) A factory that makes new toys
- (C) A landfill for the whole country
- (D) A yearly toy-repair clinic and fix-it workshops

5. What does Amsterdam hope to have by 2050?

- (A) Almost no waste
- (B) Bigger shops
- (C) More landfills
- (D) No more bicycles

6. What can cities do as big buyers?

- (A) Throw away broken things faster
- (B) Build more landfills
- (C) Ask companies for greener goods
- (D) Stop buying anything

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: B 4: D 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):